

that the RAF would run out of airplanes. But the rate of attrition among experienced fliers meant that men with virtually no experience of flying single-seat fighters were soon being drafted. On their first few excursions, novices could only hope to survive through pure luck.

Britain was fortunate in having its Commonwealth and occupied Europe to draw on for personnel. Fighter Command was an international force, with Canadians, New Zealanders, South Africans, Australians, many Poles and Czechs, some Belgians and Free French, and even a handful of Americans serving alongside the British. Each contingent had its own distinctive character – the Poles were described by Dowding as “very dashing and totally undisciplined” – but they all shared youthful courage and enjoyed the status their profession gave them with women.

Among British pilots, class distinction was rife. Pilot officers who had come into the RAF through the peacetime Auxiliary Air Force and University Air Squadrons – run as exclusive clubs for young men from well-off families – were sharply distinguished from the sergeant pilots who had

graduated from the nonexclusive Volunteer Reserve. Officers and sergeants flew side by side, but they were positively discouraged from socializing.

In the air, an experience shared by many RAF pilots in the Battle of Britain was that of being shot down. Pilots in the busiest sectors could expect to be forced to bale out at least once a month. With men more valuable than machines, it made little sense to perform heroics nursing a damaged airplane to safety – though some pilots still did. If having parachutes was the sharpest difference between the experience of World War II fliers and their World War I predecessors, the most striking resemblance was the terrible fear of fire. Pilots wrapped themselves around with clothing to cover any bare flesh, hoping to extend by a second or two the time they might have to escape the cockpit without disfiguring burns.

“The few”

As in World War I, a disproportionate number of kills in the Battle of Britain were recorded by a few gifted individuals. The required combination of flying skills, sharp eyesight, fast reaction times, and killer instinct was rare. The top Battle of Britain ace in the RAF, credited with 17 kills, was a Czech pilot, Josef Frantisek, flying with a Polish squadron. The highest score for a British RAF pilot was recorded by Sergeant Ginger Lacey – one in the eye for the class system. In the Luftwaffe, the two most trumpeted aces, Adolf Galland and Werner Mölders, vied with Major Helmut Wick in a highly publicized contest for top score. Although some pilots in Britain achieved fame – for example, the legless Douglas Bader – the RAF discouraged competition over kills and individual hero-worship. Even in Germany, the aces did not have the same public status as in World War I. The need for air heroes to cement public support for the war was not felt as keenly.

ADOLF “SAILOR” MALAN

ADOLF “SAILOR” MALAN (1905–63), one of the RAF’s top fighter aces, was brought up on a farm in South Africa. Used to firing a gun since childhood – which may account for his excellent shooting in the cockpit – Malan joined the RAF in 1935. Leader of 74 Squadron from August 1940, he schooled his men in the need for dedicated teamwork and constant practice. He applied himself to killing Germans in a professional and methodical spirit, but had no time for “score chasing.” A tactical experimenter, he broke away from the rigid tight-V formation officially required by the RAF, and circulated his own “Ten Rules of Air Fighting.”



“SAILOR” AND MASCOT

Malan was called “Sailor” because he had once been a merchant seaman. Aged 30 at the time of the Battle of Britain, he was an old man by fighter-pilot standards.



Fighter Command pilots were definitely, as Churchill dubbed them, “the few” to which so much was owed. The number killed in the Battle of Britain was 544 – about one in five of those RAF pilots who took part. Luftwaffe airmen died in much greater numbers – around 2,700 of them. The difference was mostly due to the toll taken of bomber aircrews. Overall, the RAF is estimated to have shot down around 1,900 Luftwaffe aircraft for the loss of just over a thousand of their own.

There were days in late August and early September when Fighter Command was severely stretched. Luftwaffe raids on airfields had ground crew and civilian support services battling heroically to fill craters and restore communications. Repeatedly scrambled to meet harrying attacks, RAF pilots suffered periods of

DOUGHTY INTERCEPTORS

RAF Hawker Hurricanes fly in close formation. During the Battle of Britain, Hurricanes were the bomber-killers of choice – intercepting Dorniers and Heinkels – while Spitfires engaged the Bf 109s that shadowed the German bombers at high altitude.